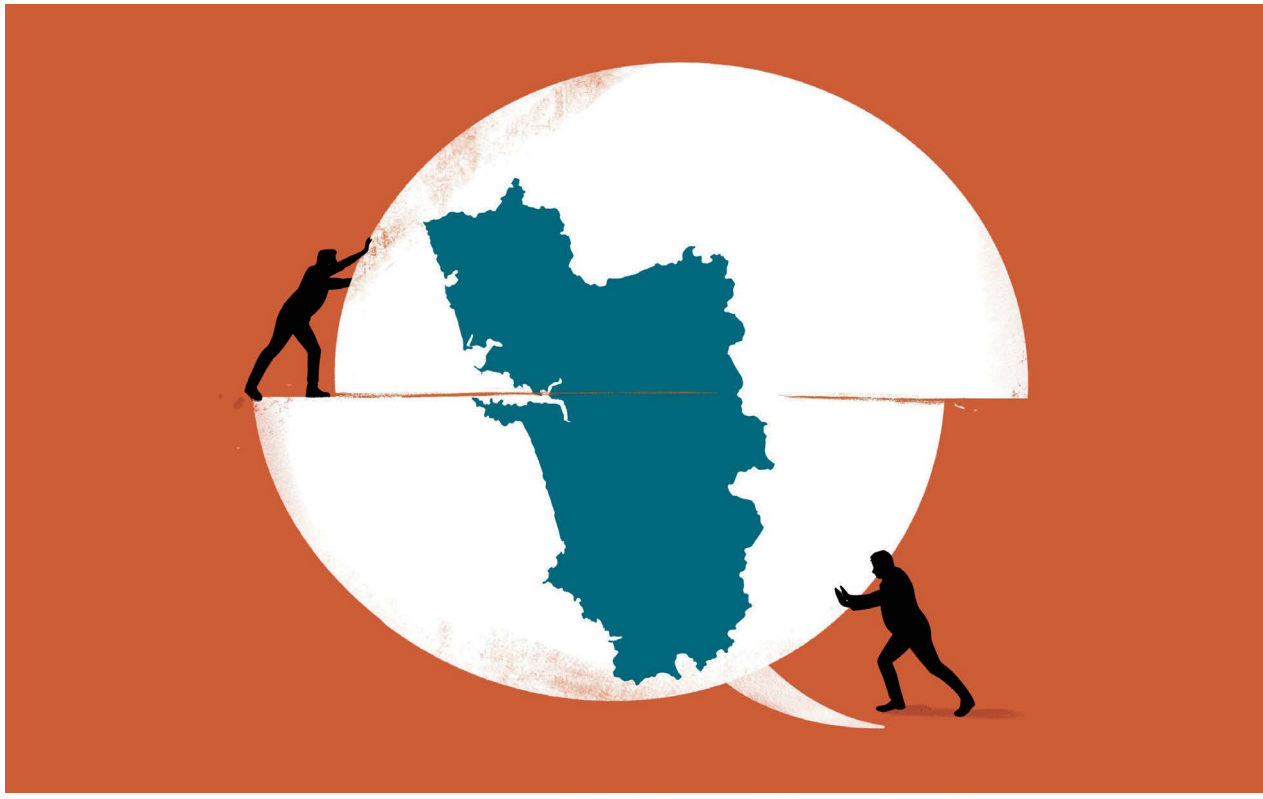
STATE SCAN

GUJARAT: THE GENE HUNT SPORT *PG 22*

TELANGANA: AN IAS TRANSFER SPREE *PG 24*



▶ GOA

MARATHI VERSUS KONKANI

An old ghost stalks pre-poll Goa. Marathi activists demand official status for their language. Konkani speakers say 'naka'

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IN GOA, A FOUNDING TENSION HAS AGAIN FOUND WORDS to speak its mind. And speakers hard to dismiss for the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Fanning the embers of a language war almost as old as Goa, Subhash Velingkar, a rare renegade from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) who formerly headed its local chapter, has launched a movement seeking co-official status for Marathi. If the demand is not fulfilled, he warns, the Marathi vote bank would vote against the BJP in the 2027 state polls.

In response, Konkani activists, too, have switched to battle mode—their language, they warn, is central to Goa's identity and any party promising to upgrade Marathi's status would face a Konkani backlash. A section, largely comprising Catholics, also wants Konkani in the Roman script—called Romi Konknni or Concanim—to be recognised as an official script.

The status quo leaves things in a half-formed compromise. In 1987, after a two-year agitation that saw seven deaths (and a language martyr in tribal youngster Floriano Vaz), Konkani in the Devnagari script was recognised as Goa's official language. The law also provides that Marathi

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE